

Jeremiah 13 - 15

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight we walk through three chapters that move from a rotted piece of cloth, to a sky that will not open, to a prophet who tells God the truth about how badly this is going.

A linen belt buried by a river and dug up worthless.

Cracked ground, empty jars, and children sent to cisterns that have nothing in them.

A man who ate the words of Yahweh with joy, and then asked Him to His face whether He had turned out to be a dry streambed.

Jeremiah 13 takes the most intimate garment a man owns and makes it a parable: Israel was meant to cling to Yahweh the way that cloth clings to a waist - and pride is what pried it loose.

Jeremiah 14 turns the drought outside into the drought inside, and lands on the hardest sentence an intercessor can ever be handed: "Don't pray for this people for their good."

Jeremiah 15 refuses even Moses and Samuel, then turns unexpectedly personal - and ends with Yahweh calling His own prophet to repent, and promising to make him a wall of bronze if he does.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 13 - The Ruined Belt and the Pride That Would Not Cling

Key Notes

- Yahweh tells Jeremiah to buy a linen belt and never wash it - a garment worn against the skin, kept unlaundered, and therefore carrying the man's own sweat and smell. Intimacy is the whole point before judgment is ever mentioned (Jeremiah 13:1-2).
- The belt is buried in a cleft of rock by the Euphrates and later dug up ruined, good for nothing. The sign-act costs Jeremiah a long journey twice over, and produces one object lesson (Jeremiah 13:3-7).
- The interpretation is pride: "In this way I will ruin the pride of Judah, and the great pride of Jerusalem." The rot is not imposed from outside - it is what separation from Yahweh does on its own (Jeremiah 13:8-10).
- The purpose clause is the tenderest line in the chapter: Yahweh made Israel and Judah cling to Him "that they may be to me for a people, for a name, for praise, and for glory; but they would not hear" (Jeremiah 13:11).
- A second sign follows in the form of a proverb everyone already agrees with - jars get filled with wine - which Yahweh turns inside out: He will fill kings, priests, and prophets with drunkenness and dash them against each other (Jeremiah 13:12-14).
- "Give glory to Yahweh your God, before he causes darkness" is an appeal with a deadline attached. There is still light to walk in, and there is a point at which the looking for light itself becomes the tragedy (Jeremiah 13:15-16).
- If they will not hear, Jeremiah's response is not vindication but private weeping - "my soul will weep in secret for your pride" - because Yahweh's flock has been taken captive (Jeremiah 13:17).
- The king and the queen mother are told to sit down; the crowns are already off. Judah is spoken of as carried away captive in the perfect tense, as though the exile has already happened (Jeremiah 13:18-19).
- The shepherds are asked the one question they cannot answer: "Where is the flock that was given to you, your beautiful flock?" Leadership is measured by what happened to the sheep (Jeremiah 13:20-21).
- "Can the Ethiopian change his skin, or the leopard his spots?" is not fatalism but honest diagnosis - habitual evil has become second nature, and nothing short of a new nature will do (Jeremiah 13:22-23).
- The chapter ends with a woe and an unanswered question: "You will not be made clean. How long will it yet be?" - a door left visibly open even in a sentence of shame (Jeremiah 13:24-27).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Linen Worn Close - the Priestly Cloth	Jeremiah 13:1 • Leviticus 16:4 • Exodus 28:42-43

Topic	References
Buried by the Euphrates - the Direction of Exile	Jeremiah 13:4-7 • Jeremiah 2:18 • 2 Kings 24:7
Pride Ruined Before Yahweh	Jeremiah 13:9 • Proverbs 16:18 • Isaiah 2:11-12
Made to Cling - a People for His Name	Jeremiah 13:11 • Exodus 19:5-6 • Deuteronomy 26:18-19
The Cup That Makes Nations Stagger	Jeremiah 13:13 • Isaiah 51:17 • Psalm 75:8
Light Sought, Darkness Found	Jeremiah 13:16 • Amos 5:18-20 • Isaiah 59:9-10
Shepherds Asked for the Flock	Jeremiah 13:20 • Jeremiah 23:1-2 • Ezekiel 34:2-4
A Nature That Cannot Change Itself	Jeremiah 13:23 • Job 14:4 • Romans 3:10-12

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Garment of Righteousness Put On Us	Jeremiah 13:1 • Isaiah 61:10 • Revelation 19:8
The Branch That Withers Apart From Him	Jeremiah 13:7 • John 15:6 • Romans 11:17-21
Brought Near to Cling - a Chosen People	Jeremiah 13:11 • Ephesians 2:12-13 • 1 Peter 2:9
Walk While You Have the Light	Jeremiah 13:16 • John 12:35-36 • John 8:12
The Shepherd Who Does Not Lose the Flock	Jeremiah 13:20 • John 10:11 • 1 Peter 5:4
A New Heart Given, Not Manufactured	Jeremiah 13:23 • Ezekiel 36:26-27 • 2 Corinthians 5:17
The Washing That Truly Makes Clean	Jeremiah 13:27 • Ephesians 5:25-27 • Titus 2:14

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 13 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - verse-by-verse treatment of the linen belt sign-act and the oracle against pride
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 13](#) - covenant-framed, Torah-honoring reading of the belt as a picture of Israel's calling
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 13](#) - exposition of the sign-acts and the leopard's-spots diagnosis of ingrained sin

Jeremiah 13 - Opening Intro

The English word "belt" does this chapter no favors. The Hebrew is ezor - a waistcloth, the innermost garment, the one thing a man wears that no one else sees. Yahweh does not ask Jeremiah to buy a sash

for display. He asks him to buy the piece of cloth that lives against the skin, and then He forbids him to wash it, so that it takes on the shape and the smell of the man wearing it.

That is the picture Yahweh chooses for what Israel was supposed to be to Him. And the verb in verse 11 makes it unmistakable: the word for “cling” is *dabaq*, the same word used in Genesis when a man leaves his father and mother and cleaves to his wife. This is covenant marriage language wrapped around a piece of linen.

Then He tells the prophet to bury it. Whether the destination was the Euphrates itself - a seven-hundred-mile round trip, done twice - or the village of Parah a few miles from Anathoth, which is spelled almost identically in Hebrew, the point survives either reading. The cloth goes to the place exile comes from, and comes back good for nothing.

Notice what actually ruined it. No one attacked it. No one cut it. It simply lay away from the waist it belonged to, in damp rock, until it rotted. That is the whole doctrine of the chapter in one image: separation does not need an enemy to do its work. Given enough time, distance alone is sufficient.

Before we read, hold the tenderness underneath the threat. Yahweh does not say He wanted a well-behaved nation. He says He caused them to cling to Him so that they would be to Him “for a people, for a name, for praise, and for glory.” He wanted them the way a man wants the shirt on his own back. The grief in this chapter is the grief of something meant to be worn and left in the ground instead.

Jeremiah 13:1-27 (WEB)

1 Yahweh said to me, “Go, and buy yourself a linen belt, and put it on your waist, and don’t put it in water.”^{1,2}

2 So I bought a belt according to Yahweh’s word, and put it on my waist.

3 Yahweh’s word came to me the second time, saying,

4 “Take the belt that you have bought, which is on your waist, and arise, go to the Euphrates, and hide it there in a cleft of the rock.”³

5 So I went, and hid it by the Euphrates, as Yahweh commanded me.

6 After many days, Yahweh said to me, “Arise, go to the Euphrates, and take the belt from there, which I commanded you to hide there.”

¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Leviticus 16:4](#) • [Exodus 28:42-43](#) - linen as the garment worn next to the priest’s own body in the presence of Yahweh

² **Messianic Connection:** [Isaiah 61:10](#) • [Revelation 19:8](#) - the garment of salvation put on us, the fine linen that is the righteous acts of the saints

³ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 2:18](#) • [2 Kings 24:7](#) - the Euphrates as both the lure of foreign alliance and the road exile would actually travel

7 Then I went to the Euphrates, and dug, and took the belt from the place where I had hidden it; and behold, the belt was ruined. It was profitable for nothing.⁴

8 Then Yahweh's word came to me, saying,

9 "Yahweh says, 'In this way I, will ruin the pride of Judah, and the great pride of Jerusalem.

10 This evil people, who refuse to hear my words, who walk in the stubbornness of their heart, and have gone after other gods to serve them, and to worship them, will even be as this belt, which is profitable for nothing.

11 For as the belt clings to the waist of a man, so I have caused the whole house of Israel and the whole house of Judah to cling to me,' says Yahweh; 'that they may be to me for a people, for a name, for praise, and for glory; but they would not hear.'^{5,6}

12 "Therefore you shall speak to them this word: 'Yahweh, the God of Israel says, "Every bottle should be filled with wine."' They will tell you, 'Do we not certainly know that every bottle should be filled with wine?'

13 Then tell them, 'Yahweh says, "Behold, I will fill all the inhabitants of this land, even the kings who sit on David's throne, the priests, the prophets, and all the inhabitants of Jerusalem, with drunkenness.

14 I will dash them one against another, even the fathers and the sons together," says Yahweh: "I will not pity, spare, or have compassion, that I should not destroy them."'"

15 Hear, and give ear. Don't be proud, for Yahweh has spoken.

16 Give glory to Yahweh your God, before he causes darkness, and before your feet stumble on the dark mountains, and, while you look for light, he turns it into the shadow of death, and makes it deep darkness.^{7,8}

17 But if you will not hear it, my soul will weep in secret for your pride. My eye will weep bitterly, and run down with tears, because Yahweh's flock has been taken captive.⁹

18 Say to the king and to the queen mother, "Humble yourselves. Sit down, for your crowns have come down, even the crown of your glory.

⁴ **Messianic Connection:** [John 15:6](#) • [Romans 11:17-21](#) - the branch that does not abide withers and is good for nothing but burning

⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Exodus 19:5-6](#) • [Deuteronomy 26:18-19](#) - a treasured possession set high for praise, for name, and for honor above all nations

⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [Ephesians 2:12-13](#) • [1 Peter 2:9](#) - those once far off brought near, made a chosen race and a people for God's own possession

⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Amos 5:18-20](#) • [Isaiah 59:9-10](#) - the day of Yahweh as darkness and not light, and groping at noon like the blind

⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [John 12:35-36](#) • [John 8:12](#) - walk while you have the light, before the darkness overtakes you

⁹ **Messianic Connection:** [Luke 19:41-44](#) • [Matthew 23:37](#) - the greater Prophet weeping over the same city, over the same refusal to be gathered

19 The cities of the South is shut up, and there is no one to open them. Judah is carried away captive: all of it. It is wholly carried away captive.

20 Lift up your eyes, and see those who come from the north. Where is the flock that was given to you, your beautiful flock?¹⁰

21 What will you say, when he sets over you as head those whom you have yourself taught to be friends to you? Won't sorrows take hold of you, as of a woman in travail?

22 If you say in your heart, "Why have these things come on me?" Your skirts are uncovered because of the greatness of your iniquity, and your heels suffer violence.

23 Can the Ethiopian change his skin, or the leopard his spots? Then may you also do good, who are accustomed to do evil.^{11,12}

24 "Therefore I will scatter them, as the stubble that passes away, by the wind of the wilderness.

25 This is your lot, the portion measured to you from me," says Yahweh, "because you have forgotten me, and trusted in falsehood."

26 Therefore will I also uncover your skirts on your face, and your shame will appear.

27 I have seen your abominations, even your adulteries, and your neighing, the lewdness of your prostitution, on the hills in the field. Woe to you, Jerusalem! You will not be made clean. How long will it yet be?"¹³

¹⁰ **Messianic Connection:** [John 10:11](#) • [1 Peter 5:4](#) - the Good Shepherd who lays down His life, and the chief Shepherd who will appear

¹¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Job 14:4](#) • [Romans 3:10-12](#) - no clean thing brought out of an unclean one, and no one who does good on his own

¹² **Messianic Connection:** [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#) • [2 Corinthians 5:17](#) - a heart of stone exchanged for flesh - the change no leopard can perform on itself

¹³ **Messianic Connection:** [Ephesians 5:25-27](#) • [Titus 2:14](#) - the Bridegroom who cleanses His bride by the washing of water with the word

CHAPTER 14 - The Drought, the Lying Peace, and the Prayer Refused

Key Notes

- The oracle is introduced as a word “concerning the drought” - a covenant curse spelled out centuries earlier, arriving on schedule and being read by almost no one as what it is (Jeremiah 14:1-2).
- The picture is domestic and devastating: nobles sending their servants and children to the cisterns, who come back with empty vessels and cover their heads in shame (Jeremiah 14:3-4).
- Even the animals indict the people. The doe abandons her newborn because there is no grass, and the wild donkeys stand on bare heights panting like jackals (Jeremiah 14:5-6).
- The people’s prayer is theologically perfect - “work for your name’s sake, Yahweh” - and yet Yahweh’s answer exposes it as words without turning: “they have loved to wander. They have not restrained their feet” (Jeremiah 14:7-10).
- For the third time in the book, Jeremiah is forbidden to intercede. Fasting, burnt offering, and meal offering will not be accepted; the liturgy has outlived the loyalty behind it (Jeremiah 14:11-12).
- Jeremiah pleads the people’s best excuse - the prophets told them there would be peace - and Yahweh dismantles it: “I didn’t send them. I didn’t command them. I didn’t speak to them” (Jeremiah 14:13-14).
- The false prophets will be consumed by the very sword and famine they denied, and their hearers will not be excused by having been lied to. Being deceived is not the same as being innocent (Jeremiah 14:15-16).
- Yahweh hands Jeremiah a lament to weep on His behalf - “the virgin daughter of my people is broken with a great breach” - which means the tears in this book are not only the prophet’s (Jeremiah 14:17-18).
- The closing prayer is the most honest in the chapter: it confesses wickedness, appeals to His name and His throne, and asks Him not to break covenant - and it ends by admitting no idol has ever made it rain (Jeremiah 14:19-22).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Drought as a Named Covenant Curse	Jeremiah 14:1-4 • Deuteronomy 28:23-24 • Joel 1:10-12
Empty Cisterns and Vessels Brought Back Dry	Jeremiah 14:3 • Jeremiah 2:13 • Isaiah 41:17
For Your Name’s Sake, Not Ours	Jeremiah 14:7 • Psalm 25:11 • Ezekiel 36:22
Yahweh in the Middle of Us	Jeremiah 14:9 • Exodus 33:15-16 • Deuteronomy 31:6
Intercession Forbidden	Jeremiah 14:11 • Jeremiah 7:16 • Jeremiah 11:14
“Peace, Peace” From Prophets Never	Jeremiah 14:13-14 • Jeremiah 6:14 • Ezekiel 13:10

Topic	References
Sent	
The Test of the Unsent Prophet	Jeremiah 14:14-15 • Jeremiah 23:21 • Deuteronomy 18:20
Covenant Remembered, Not Broken	Jeremiah 14:21 • Leviticus 26:44-45 • Psalm 106:45

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Hope of Israel, Savior in Time of Trouble	Jeremiah 14:8 • Romans 15:12-13 • 1 Timothy 1:1
Not a Stranger Passing the Night - God With Us	Jeremiah 14:9 • Matthew 1:23 • Matthew 28:20
Living Water for Empty Vessels	Jeremiah 14:3 • John 4:13-14 • Revelation 21:6
The Intercessor Who Is Never Told to Stop	Jeremiah 14:11 • Hebrews 7:25 • 1 John 2:1
The Prophet Who Wept With Loud Cries and Tears	Jeremiah 14:17 • Hebrews 5:7 • John 11:35
The Covenant Remembered in the Blood of Messiah	Jeremiah 14:21 • Hebrews 13:20 • Luke 1:72-73
Only Yahweh Sends the Rain	Jeremiah 14:22 • 1 Kings 18:39 • Psalm 147:8

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 14 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the drought oracle, the forbidden intercession, and the confrontation with the false prophets
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 14](#) - reads the drought against the blessing-and-curse structure of Leviticus 26 and Deuteronomy 28
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 14](#) - careful handling of why a doctrinally correct prayer can still be refused

Jeremiah 14 - Opening Intro

Rain in Israel was never merely weather. Deuteronomy had said it plainly: obedience meant rain in its season, and rebellion meant a sky like bronze and ground like iron. So when the cisterns run dry in this chapter, the drought is not a natural disaster that happens to coincide with a sermon. The drought is the sermon.

And the detail that stays with you is small. Nobles send their little ones to the water and they come home with empty jars and cover their heads. Not the army defeated, not the temple burned - just children walking back with nothing, and grown men who cannot look at them.

Then the people pray, and here is the difficulty of this chapter: the prayer is good. It confesses iniquity. It appeals to Yahweh's name rather than to their own merit. It calls Him the hope of Israel. If you read verses 7 through 9 by themselves, you would expect mercy on the next line. What comes instead is a refusal, and then something harder - a command not to pray at all.

The reason is given in one clause: "they have loved to wander. They have not restrained their feet." The words were right. The feet never changed direction. Yahweh is not being harsh with language here; He is being exact about the difference between a prayer and a turn.

And notice who does not stop grieving. When Jeremiah is told to stop interceding, Yahweh hands him a lament to say instead - "let my eyes run down with tears night and day." Even a judgment this settled is not delivered dry-eyed.

Before we read, carry this: the most dangerous sermon in Judah was not the one calling for repentance. It was the one promising assured peace, preached by men nobody had sent.

Jeremiah 14:1-22 (WEB)

1 This is Yahweh's word that came to Jeremiah concerning the drought.

2 "Judah mourns, and its gates languish. They sit in black on the ground. The cry of Jerusalem goes up.¹⁴

3 Their nobles send their little ones to the waters. They come to the cisterns, and find no water. They return with their vessels empty. They are disappointed and confounded, and cover their heads.¹⁵

4 Because of the ground which is cracked, because no rain has been in the land, the plowmen are disappointed. They cover their heads.

5 Yes, the doe in the field also calves and forsakes her young, because there is no grass.

6 The wild donkeys stand on the bare heights. They pant for air like jackals. Their eyes fail, because there is no vegetation.

7 Though our iniquities testify against us, work for your name's sake, Yahweh; for our rebellions are many. We have sinned against you.

8 You hope of Israel, its Savior in the time of trouble, why should you be as a foreigner in the land, and as a wayfaring man who turns aside to stay for a night?¹⁶

¹⁴ Cross-Reference: [Deuteronomy 28:23-24](#) • [Joel 1:10-12](#) - the sky as bronze and the ground as iron - drought named in advance as covenant discipline

¹⁵ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 2:13](#) • [Isaiah 41:17](#) - broken cisterns that hold no water, and the poor seeking water and finding none

9 Why should you be like a scared man, as a mighty man who can't save? Yet you, Yahweh, are in the middle of us, and we are called by your name. Don't leave us.^{17,18}

10 Yahweh says to this people, "Even so they have loved to wander. They have not restrained their feet. Therefore Yahweh does not accept them. Now he will remember their iniquity, and punish them for their sins."

11 Yahweh said to me, "Don't pray for this people for their good."^{19,20}

12 When they fast, I will not hear their cry; and when they offer burnt offering and meal offering, I will not accept them; but I will consume them by the sword, by famine, and by pestilence."

13 Then I said, "Ah, Lord Yahweh! Behold, the prophets tell them, 'You will not see the sword, neither will you have famine; but I will give you assured peace in this place.'"²¹

14 Then Yahweh said to me, "The prophets prophesy lies in my name. I didn't send them. I didn't command them. I didn't speak to them. They prophesy to you a lying vision, divination, and a thing of nothing, and the deceit of their own heart."²²

15 Therefore Yahweh says concerning the prophets who prophesy in my name, but I didn't send them, yet they say, 'Sword and famine will not be in this land.' Those prophets will be consumed by sword and famine.

16 The people to whom they prophesy will be cast out in the streets of Jerusalem because of the famine and the sword. They will have no one to bury them—they, their wives, their sons, or their daughters, for I will pour their wickedness on them.

17 "You shall say this word to them: "'Let my eyes run down with tears night and day, and let them not cease; for the virgin daughter of my people is broken with a great breach, with a very grievous wound."²³

18 If I go out into the field, then, behold, the slain with the sword! If I enter into the city, then, behold, those who are sick with famine! For both the prophet and the priest go about in the land, and have no knowledge."

¹⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [Romans 15:12-13](#) • [1 Timothy 1:1](#) - the root of Jesse in whom the nations hope - Messiah Yahshua our hope

¹⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Exodus 33:15-16](#) • [Deuteronomy 31:6](#) - the presence that distinguishes this people, and the promise never to leave or forsake

¹⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 1:23](#) • [Matthew 28:20](#) - Immanuel, God with us, present to the very end of the age

¹⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 7:16](#) • [Jeremiah 11:14](#) - the third time in the book that Jeremiah is forbidden to intercede for Judah

²⁰ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 7:25](#) • [1 John 2:1](#) - the One who always lives to intercede, an Advocate with the Father who is never silenced

²¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 6:14](#) • [Ezekiel 13:10](#) - healing the wound lightly, crying peace where there is no peace

²² **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 23:21](#) • [Deuteronomy 18:20](#) - prophets who ran though they were not sent, and the Torah's sentence upon them

²³ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 5:7](#) • [John 11:35](#) - loud cries and tears offered up by the One who wept before the tomb

19 Have you utterly rejected Judah? Has your soul loathed Zion? Why have you struck us, and there is no healing for us? We looked for peace, but no good came; and for a time of healing, and behold, dismay!

20 We acknowledge, Yahweh, our wickedness, and the iniquity of our fathers; for we have sinned against you.

21 Do not abhor us, for your name's sake. Do not disgrace the throne of your glory. Remember, and don't break your covenant with us.²⁴

22 Are there any among the vanities of the nations that can cause rain? Or can the sky give showers? Aren't you he, Yahweh our God? Therefore we will wait for you; for you have made all these things.²⁵

²⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Leviticus 26:44-45](#) • [Psalm 106:45](#) - the covenant Yahweh refuses to break even when His people have broken it

²⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [1 Kings 18:39](#) • [Psalm 147:8](#) - the God who answers by fire and covers the sky with clouds - no idol has ever made rain

CHAPTER 15 - Intercession Denied and a Prophet Recommissioned

Key Notes

- Yahweh names the two greatest intercessors in Israel's memory - Moses, who turned away wrath at Sinai, and Samuel, who prayed and thunder came - and says that even they could not move Him now (Jeremiah 15:1).
- The grim litany of verse 2 is a sorting, not a slaughter: death, sword, famine, captivity. Every person will go somewhere, and the only question left is which door (Jeremiah 15:2-3).
- Manasseh is named as the reason. Two generations later, and after Josiah's reforms, the blood he shed in Jerusalem is still on the ledger - sin has a longer shadow than a single reign (Jeremiah 15:4).
- "I am weary of showing compassion" is one of the most staggering sentences in Scripture, and it comes after "you have gone backward" - the weariness is not arbitrary, it is exhaustion at a hand extended too long (Jeremiah 15:5-7).
- Then, without warning, the chapter turns personal. Jeremiah breaks in with "Woe is me, my mother, that you have borne me" - he owes nothing to anyone and is cursed by everyone anyway (Jeremiah 15:10).
- Yahweh's first answer is not correction but promise: "Most certainly I will strengthen you for good" - and then a question about iron from the north that no one in Judah can break (Jeremiah 15:11-14).
- Jeremiah's testimony is the high-water mark of the book: "Your words were found, and I ate them. Your words were to me a joy and the rejoicing of my heart" (Jeremiah 15:15-16).
- The cost of that meal is named in the very next breath - he sat alone, out of the assembly of those who make merry, filled with Yahweh's own indignation (Jeremiah 15:17).
- His complaint goes further than most of us dare: he accuses Yahweh of being a wadi, a stream that runs in the rainy season and is dust when you actually need it (Jeremiah 15:18).
- The answer is astonishing. Yahweh does not defend Himself and does not condemn the prophet - He calls him to repent. "If you return, then I will bring you again, that you may stand before me" (Jeremiah 15:19).
- The chapter closes by re-issuing the original call of chapter 1, word for word and stronger: a fortified bronze wall, fought against but never overcome, delivered and redeemed (Jeremiah 15:20-21).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Moses and Samuel - the Great Intercessors	Jeremiah 15:1 • Exodus 32:11-14 • 1 Samuel 12:23
Manasseh's Long Shadow	Jeremiah 15:4 • 2 Kings 21:11-16 • 2 Kings 23:26

Topic	References
Gone Backward, Not Merely Astray	Jeremiah 15:6 • Isaiah 1:4 • Jeremiah 8:5
Winnowed at the Gates of the Land	Jeremiah 15:7 • Amos 9:9 • Matthew 3:12
The Prophet Who Curses His Birthday	Jeremiah 15:10 • Jeremiah 20:14-18 • Job 3:1-3
Eating the Words of Yahweh	Jeremiah 15:16 • Ezekiel 3:1-3 • Deuteronomy 8:3
Is God a Brook That Fails?	Jeremiah 15:18 • Job 6:15-17 • Psalm 22:1
Recommissioned as a Bronze Wall	Jeremiah 15:19-20 • Jeremiah 1:18-19 • Isaiah 50:7

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Intercessor Who Is Never Turned Away	Jeremiah 15:1 • Romans 8:34 • Isaiah 53:12
Hated Without Cause, a Man of Contention	Jeremiah 15:10 • John 15:18-20 • Luke 6:22
The Word Eaten - Sweet in the Mouth	Jeremiah 15:16 • Revelation 10:9-10 • John 6:63
The One Who Sat Alone	Jeremiah 15:17 • Isaiah 53:3 • Hebrews 12:1-3
My God, Why Have You Forsaken Me?	Jeremiah 15:18 • Matthew 27:46 • Isaiah 53:4
A Vessel for Honor - Speaking Only His Words	Jeremiah 15:19 • 2 Timothy 2:20-21 • John 12:49
Redeemed Out of the Hand of the Terrible	Jeremiah 15:21 • Colossians 1:13 • Psalm 34:19

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 15 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the refusal of intercession, Jeremiah's second confession, and the recommissioning in verse 19
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 15](#) - the Manasseh reference and the question of generational consequence under the covenant
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 15](#) - close reading of the prophet's complaint and Yahweh's unexpected call for him to repent

Jeremiah 15 - Opening Intro

Yahweh reaches for the two heaviest names He has. Moses stood in the breach at Sinai while the gold calf was still warm, and the sentence was withdrawn. Samuel prayed and the Philistines scattered. If there were a court of appeal above Jeremiah's pay grade, those two men were it. And Yahweh says: even them. Even they would not turn Me now.

That is where the chapter starts, and it is worth sitting in for a moment before rushing to the comfort at the end. There is such a thing as a moment when the window closes - not because God ran out of mercy, but because a people spent every offer of it.

Then the chapter does something almost startling. It stops talking about Judah and starts talking about Jeremiah. "Woe is me, my mother, that you have borne me." He points out that he has not lent money and has not borrowed - he has given nobody a reason to hate him - and everybody hates him anyway.

In the middle of that comes verse 16, which is the reason many of us love this book: "Your words were found, and I ate them." Not studied. Not admired. Eaten. And the next verse tells you what eating them cost: he never sat in the room where people were laughing.

Then he says the unsayable. In Hebrew the image is a wadi - a desert streambed that roars after the winter rain and is bone dry in August, exactly when a traveler stakes his life on finding water there. Jeremiah looks at Yahweh and asks whether He has turned out to be one of those. It is in Scripture. It was not edited out.

And Yahweh's reply is the hinge of the whole chapter. He does not scold, and He does not explain Himself. He says: if you return, I will bring you back. The prophet who has spent fifteen chapters calling Judah to repent is now called to repent himself - the same verb, *shuv*, turned around and handed to him.

Before we read, notice the order carefully. The bronze wall in verse 20 comes after the call to return in verse 19, not before it. Yahweh does not make a man unbreakable and then ask him to yield. He asks him to yield, and then He makes him unbreakable.

Jeremiah 15:1-21 (WEB)

1 Then Yahweh said to me, "Though Moses and Samuel stood before me, yet my mind would not be toward this people. Cast them out of my sight, and let them go out!"^{26,27}

2 It will happen, when they tell you, 'Where shall we go out?' Then you shall tell them, 'Yahweh says: "Such as are for death, to death; such as are for the sword, to the sword; such as are for the famine, to the famine; and such as are for captivity, to captivity."' "

3 "I will appoint over them four kinds," says Yahweh: "the sword to kill, the dogs to tear, the birds of the sky, and the animals of the earth, to devour and to destroy.

4 I will cause them to be tossed back and forth among all the kingdoms of the earth, because of Manasseh, the son of Hezekiah, king of Judah, for that which he did in Jerusalem."²⁸

²⁶ Cross-Reference: [Exodus 32:11-14](#) • [1 Samuel 12:23](#) - the two intercessions Israel remembered best - and the prophet who called failing to pray a sin

²⁷ Messianic Connection: [Romans 8:34](#) • [Isaiah 53:12](#) - the Intercessor at the right hand of God, who bore sin and made intercession for transgressors

²⁸ Cross-Reference: [2 Kings 21:11-16](#) • [2 Kings 23:26](#) - Manasseh's innocent blood, which even Josiah's reformation did not undo

5 For who will have pity on you, Jerusalem? Who will mourn you? Who will come to ask of your welfare?

6 You have rejected me,” says Yahweh. “You have gone backward. Therefore I have stretched out my hand against you, and destroyed you. I am weary of showing compassion.

7 I have winnowed them with a fan in the gates of the land. I have bereaved them of children. I have destroyed my people. They didn’t return from their ways.

8 Their widows are increased more than the sand of the seas; I have brought on them against the mother of the young men a destroyer at noonday. I have caused anguish and terrors to fall on her suddenly.

9 She who has borne seven languishes. She has given up the spirit. Her sun has gone down while it was yet day. She has been disappointed and confounded. I will deliver their residue to the sword before their enemies,” says Yahweh.

10 Woe is me, my mother, that you have borne me, a man of strife, and a man of contention to the whole earth! I have not lent, neither have men lent to me; yet every one of them curses me.²⁹

11 Yahweh said, “Most certainly I will strengthen you for good. Most certainly I will cause the enemy to make supplication to you in the time of evil and in the time of affliction.

12 Can one break iron, even iron from the north, and brass?

13 I will give your substance and your treasures for a plunder without price, and that for all your sins, even in all your borders.

14 I will make them to pass with your enemies into a land which you don’t know; for a fire is kindled in my anger, which will burn on you.”

15 Yahweh, you know. Remember me, visit me, and avenge me of my persecutors. You are patient, so don’t take me away. Know that for your sake I have suffered reproach.

16 Your words were found, and I ate them. Your words were to me a joy and the rejoicing of my heart, for I am called by your name, Yahweh, God of Armies.³⁰⁻³¹

17 I didn’t sit in the assembly of those who make merry and rejoice. I sat alone because of your hand, for you have filled me with indignation.³²

²⁹ **Messianic Connection:** [John 15:18-20](#) • [Luke 6:22](#) - the servant is not greater than his master - hated by the world that hated Him first

³⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Ezekiel 3:1-3](#) • [Deuteronomy 8:3](#) - the scroll eaten and found sweet, and man living by every word from Yahweh’s mouth

³¹ **Messianic Connection:** [Revelation 10:9-10](#) • [John 6:63](#) - the little book sweet in the mouth and bitter after, and words that are spirit and life

³² **Messianic Connection:** [Isaiah 53:3](#) • [Hebrews 12:1-3](#) - a man of sorrows who endured such hostility from sinners against Himself

18 Why is my pain perpetual, and my wound incurable, which refuses to be healed? Will you indeed be to me as a deceitful brook, like waters that fail?^{33,34}

19 Therefore Yahweh says, "If you return, then I will bring you again, that you may stand before me; and if you take out the precious from the vile, you will be as my mouth. They will return to you, but you will not return to them."^{35,36}

20 I will make you to this people a fortified bronze wall. They will fight against you, but they will not prevail against you; for I am with you to save you and to deliver you," says Yahweh.³⁷

21 "I will deliver you out of the hand of the wicked, and I will redeem you out of the hand of the terrible."

³³ **Cross-Reference:** [Job 6:15-17](#) • [Psalm 22:1](#) - brothers as treacherous as a wadi, and the cry of a man who feels abandoned

³⁴ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 27:46](#) • [Isaiah 53:4](#) - the same question asked from the cross by the One who was stricken and afflicted

³⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Zechariah 3:7](#) • [Exodus 4:12](#) - the promise of a place to stand and a mouth taught what to say

³⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [2 Timothy 2:20-21](#) • [John 12:49](#) - a vessel set apart for honor, speaking nothing but what the Father gives him to speak

³⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 1:18-19](#) • [Isaiah 50:7](#) - the original commission re-issued, and the face set like flint against opposition

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 13-15

- Covenant as clinging, not merely compliance - a people meant to be worn against Yahweh like linen
- Pride as the specific rot that pries a nation loose, and separation that ruins without needing an enemy
- Sin that becomes second nature, and the honest admission that no leopard changes its own spots
- Drought, empty cisterns, and the physical world preaching what the pulpits refused to say
- The lying comfort of unsent prophets, and the fact that being deceived is not the same as being innocent
- Intercession forbidden - the terrible mercy of a door that a people themselves closed
- Yahweh's own grief inside His judgment: tears commanded, not merely permitted
- A prophet's raw complaint brought straight to God, accusation and all, and not edited out of Scripture
- Words eaten as food, and the loneliness that comes with digesting them
- Repentance asked of the messenger, and a bronze wall promised only on the far side of it

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who wanted Israel close as the cloth against His own waist find us willing to be that near, and may nothing we are proud of ever be worth the distance it costs us.

May He keep us from the slow ruin that needs no enemy - the drift, the burying, the many days in a cleft of rock - and may He dig us up before we are good for nothing.

May He give us the honesty to admit what we cannot change in ourselves, and the faith to ask Him for the new heart He has already promised rather than another resolution we cannot keep.

May He make us people who restrain our feet and not only our words, so that our prayers and our walking are pointed in the same direction.

May He guard us from every voice that promises assured peace where He has not spoken it, and give us ears that can tell the difference between comfort and truth.

May His words be found by us and eaten, and may they be the joy and the rejoicing of our hearts even on the nights we sit alone because of them.

And when we come to Him dry and accusing, as Jeremiah did, may we hear what he heard - not rebuke, but an invitation to return - and may we take it, and be made a wall of bronze in the place He puts us.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.